Bleeding Gold

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by kyasuu

Summary

> “Mydei,” Phainon says finally. His eyes trace the splatters of drying blood on Mydei’s skin. They paint a picture that Phainon tries and fails not to conjure in his mind, one of just where Nikador pierced, crushed, killed–

Phainon overthinks things. Mydei tries to help.

Notes

let me know if i missed a tag somewhere! i haven't written hsr fic in a while but i liked these two enough for it.

See the end of the work for more notes

Nikador crumbles away, dissipating into flecks of golden light. For a long moment, the world seems to stand still, like Phainon's been trapped in Oronyx's prayer.

"It's over," says Castorice quietly from behind. If Castorice says so, it must be true. Phainon lets out a breath he didn't realize he was holding, his sword suddenly an anchor in his hand.

It's over.

All of them are worse for wear but still standing when they make their way back to Okhema. They will all need medical attention when they return, but none of them are severely injured. Phainon is sore and more bruised than he has been in a long time, but he'll live.

Castorice takes the lead in silence, deep in thought. Phainon thinks to speak to her, but something tells him to stay his tongue. The travelers from beyond the sky are quiet, trailing behind and conversing between themselves. Perhaps Phainon should pay more attention, keep an ear out for anything potentially dangerous, but he has already placed his life in their hands today. It wouldn't be worth much.

His attention is reserved for someone else, either way.

Mydei walks only a few steps behind Castorice, never afraid of her presence. His pace is quick enough that Phainon would need to consciously quicken his own to match it. Phainon can't do so either, being a little too close to Castorice as it is. Intentional on Mydei's part, no doubt, even if there's no way Mydei has the energy to spare on being ridiculous.

That doesn't stop him from expending it, clearly.

"Mydei," Phainon says finally. His eyes trace the splatters of drying blood on Mydei's skin. They paint a picture that Phainon tries and fails not to conjure in his mind, one of just where Nikador pierced, crushed, killed–

Mydei doesn’t respond, but the tensing of his shoulders is acknowledgement enough for Phainon, so he presses on, plastering on a smile he doesn’t quite feel.

“Mydei,” he says again, letting a little whine bleed into his voice. Mydei has yet to ignore that tone of his. “Won’t you please slow down?”

“Having trouble keeping up?” Mydei sneers without heat, the way Phainon figured he would. A moment later, Mydei sighs, his brow furrowing. It seems neither of them have the energy for this farce. “Wipe that pity off your face, Deliverer.”

Phainon frowns. “It’s not pity. Can I not show concern for your wellbeing?”

This time, Mydei does turn to level an unimpressed look at him. “I cannot die,” he says. There’s an old bitterness in his voice when he says it, one that makes Phainon’s heart twist. “Save your *concern* for someone who needs it.”

Phainon is about to quicken his pace, Thanatos be damned, but Mydei slows down for him with a long-suffering shake of his head. Castorice doesn’t turn around or give any other indication that she can hear them, but she walks a little faster too, putting more distance between them.

“Mydei–”

“If you keep saying my name it will lose what little meaning it has.”

“*Mydei*,” Phainon repeats insistently, ignoring him. “Being immortal does not mean you do not get tired.” And even if Mydei hates that he does, Phainon knows how much dying takes out of him.

To say Mydei is deathless isn’t quite accurate. It will never take, not even by Castorice’s hand. Neither Castorice nor Mydei has told Phainon how they both know this, but Phainon can put the pieces together himself. But while Mydei never puts into words just what it feels like, Phainon has been by his side as he’s brought back from the edge of the Styx, a cold, lifeless body suddenly jerking awake with a strangled inhale.

Mydei turns his cheek. “Worry about yourself,” he says brusquely. “There are more pressing matters than injuries that have healed already.”

Phainon wishes he could argue, but Mydei isn’t exactly wrong. The Coreflame… Mydei rejected it back then, telling Phainon to take it instead, and Phainon has few illusions about changing his mind.

Many misunderstand Phainon’s relationship with Mydei, believing it more vitriolic than it is. Mydei’s reputation is the unfortunate cause, and try as Phainon might, he can only influence lifetimes of rumors so much, especially when Mydei has never cared.

That is to say, Phainon would consider Mydei a dear friend, and he’s confident that the feeling is mutual, even if Mydei would sooner cut out his own tongue than say it. They get along well enough, but they disagree on many things.

One of those things is the matter of the Coreflame, of course.

Mydei believes Phainon is a better man than he actually is. It’s both warming and uncomfortable; Phainon likes that Mydei regards him highly, but it feels like he’s lying to him, just showing the palatable parts of himself. Phainon wouldn’t call himself dishonest, but where Mydei is blunt, Phainon can be frustratingly evasive.

Something pinches his ear, hard enough to hurt. Phainon yelps, suddenly dragged out of his spiraling thoughts.

“And now you are worrying too much,” Mydei says, like he’s trying to be disgusted. It doesn’t work; he just sounds concerned. “You will be fine. Stop doubting yourself.”

It figures Mydei pinpointed Phainon’s exact issue. He’s a renown warrior, but that certainly doesn’t mean he’s stupid. Despite himself, Phainon cracks a smile.

“Are you certain you would not be a better fit?” he can’t help but ask.

“Absolutely not,” Mydei says vehemently. He scowls, shoulders hunching. “Stop bringing it up. You are the best candidate for this, Deliverer. Amphoreus does not need another mad Titan.”

Phainon sighs. He considers saying something else, but nothing comes to mind. Instead, he reaches out and puts his hand on Mydei’s arm, expecting to be shrugged off. Mydei stiffens, but then he relaxes, and Phainon’s hand remains.

Even through his glove, Mydei is warm. Alive.

Behind him, he hears the more reticent of their two guests, Dan Heng, make a strangled noise. “*Stelle*,” he says, aghast. “You can’t say that.”

“Am I *wrong*?” she grumbles. Notably, Dan Heng doesn’t argue with that point. Phainon wonders what, exactly, she said.

He doesn’t have much time to ponder; they’re almost home.

They return to Okhema heroes. Mydei is still given a wide berth, much to Phainon’s dissatisfaction, but there’s not much to be done about it.

Phainon’s injuries, although painful, aren’t too significant. It’s mostly bruising and a handful of cuts and scrapes; the same can be said for the others, much to Phainon’s relief.

Mydei, on the other hand, didn’t even bother to get himself looked over. Phainon supposes he’s not *wrong* to believe he doesn’t need to, but it still worries him.

“Maybe he’s right, Snowy,” says Tribbie, amused. “You’re worrying too much.”

“If there’s anyone worth worrying about it would be Mydei,” Phainon points out. It sounds silly when spoken aloud, especially to people who don’t know Mydei personally. Mydei himself wouldn’t suffer such a

comment. But he's not here right now, and if anyone would understand, it would be Tribbie.

Tribbie nods sagely. "You aren't wrong there," she says. "But that isn't what **We** meant. You're simply worrying about too many things too much!" Her feet leave the ground and suddenly Phainon has to look up at her as she reaches out.

Phainon lets her small hand ruffle his hair. It's undoubtedly strange, but comforting nonetheless.

"**We** know it isn't so easy," Tribbie says sympathetically. "You have a difficult road ahead of you. But you have everyone's support, including **Ours** and Agy's!" She smiles, a little slyly. "But **We** think Mydei may be the one you want to talk to about this."

She's right, because of course she is. Phainon's mouth twitches upward, feeling a lot lighter. His worries haven't fully dissipated, but they're not gnawing on him like they were earlier.

"Thank you for your counsel," he says sincerely. Aglaea has yet to summon him for the ritual, but even if she's politely waiting for him to get it together, there's only so much time she can afford to his insecurities.

Phainon takes a deep breath as Tribbie floats back down, landing on her feet and putting her hands on her hips. "He might not show it, but he's just as worried about you," Tribbie says. "He's silly like that! Just… work it out with him."

That sly smile is back. Phainon doesn't know what she means by it, but he nods earnestly anyway. "I'll go find him then," he says.

"Try his quarters," Tribbie suggests. She grins at him. "**We** hope you have a fruitful discussion!"

Unsurprisingly, Mydei is exactly where Tribbie said he would be.

Phainon hovers at the door, uncertainty stopping him from just knocking, so he paces a couple times. What does he say here? Why is he here anyway? He already knows what Mydei thinks of the situation. Mydei was the first to support his ascension.

The door opens. Phainon freezes midstep, staring wide-eyed. Mydei stands there, unimpressed.

“Do you need me or are you simply here to wear a hole through the floor?” he asks dryly.

“Hello, Mydei!” Phainon says with a little too much exuberance. Mydei’s eyebrow raises. Phainon coughs and tones it down. “I was just… thinking.”

“Don’t hurt yourself,” Mydei says. It sounds like a joke but he may as well have been completely serious.

Seeing Mydei does put Phainon at ease, though. He doesn’t have that air of horrible exhaustion that he did only a couple days ago. Phainon hates that exhaustion. It doesn’t suit him.

Apparently, Mydei was having similar thoughts because he relaxes too. Phainon wonders if he’s aware of it himself, but merely smiles about it instead of saying anything.

Mydei scowls. “What is that ridiculous look on your face for?”

Phainon can’t help but grin wider. “Nothing,” he says. Before Mydei can press him about it, Phainon switches gears. “I’m just thinking about… godhood. The Coreflame.”

Mydei studies him. “If you are getting cold feet, it may be better to wait,” he says after a long moment.

Phainon blinks, caught off guard. It’s different from what Mydei was saying before… isn’t it?

“We don’t have the time for that,” Phainon says, lips thinning. “I don’t know what they see is coming, but… Aglaea has already been very

gracious, allowing me time to recover. Unless we find someone else—”

“No,” Mydei cuts in with a shake of his head. “You alone have this right. Nikador would take only one of us, and I…”

Mydei trails off, but Phainon hears what he doesn’t say loud and clear.

I do not trust myself with it.

But he trusts Phainon, Titans know why.

Phainon stands diametrically opposed to this; Mydei may not believe it, and the people may not believe it, but Mydei is a good man. He has the discipline to keep himself in line, even if he’s afraid he doesn’t. If anyone is a good fit for Nikador, it would be him.

Phainon doesn’t want to argue again, so he doesn’t bring it up. Their stances are mirrored, but Phainon recognizes one of them will have to take on the Coreflame. Even if Phainon doesn’t quite believe he’s the right candidate, Mydei does, and Phainon will choose to believe in Mydei’s judgment instead of his own.

“Then I will bear it,” Phainon says. He’s not sure what spurs him, but he reaches out and takes one of Mydei’s hands in his own. Mydei jerks in surprise but doesn’t pull away, even if he averts his golden eyes briefly. “Thank you, Mydei.”

Saying it feels oddly final, and it’s with a jolt that Phainon realizes he’s made the decision already. Uncertainty still plagues him, whether or not he deserves it, if he should be Nikador’s champion, but he knows in his heart that he will at least try.

Something clouds Mydei’s eyes. “Phainon,” he says. It’s rare, hearing *Phainon* instead of *Deliverer* out of Mydei’s mouth. “This is not something you can rush headlong into. Aglaea would not begrudge you additional time to prepare yourself.”

Phainon runs his thumb over Mydei's knuckles. Mydei runs warm, his knuckles calloused from repeated abuse. "I will be fine," Phainon says, with more conviction than he feels. "I don't know what it is, but Tribbie and Aglaea are preparing for something big. I must be at my best for them."

Mydei meets his eyes, like he's looking for something. He must find it, because in the end, he exhales sharply and turns away, finally pulling his hand from Phainon's. Phainon's fingertips are still warm.

"Suit yourself," Mydei says. "Just do not do anything foolish."

Phainon smiles, relieved. "I will do my best."

Nikador doesn't accept him.

It isn't a rejection either. Nikador is offering him another chance, to back out or to forge forward. Phainon knows there is only one path for him to take.

He'll give Mydei a reason to believe in him.

End Notes

if you want to know what stelle said, she put a finger through an OK sign and said they needed to fuck

Thank you for reading! Comments and kudos are always loved.

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